

The Importance Of Headspace In Gaming

How Player State, Mood, And Environment Shape The Gaming Experience By Joshua Weir

Introduction: The Overlooked Variable

We've all gotten home after a long day, sat down, and booted up the latest critically acclaimed story game that demands hundreds of hours of our time, only to turn it off in less than an hour feeling drained, frustrated and disappointed. It's easy to look at this situation and immediately blame the game, decide in that moment it's not for you and is a waste of time - but the truth is, the game isn't necessarily the problem here.

The truth is, we are not the problem either. The real issue is the way we handle the rating of games. We tend to evaluate games as static objects, judged by their gameplay mechanics, graphics and narratives as fixed variables shared by everyone. In reality, it is much more personal than this. A video game is experienced by an individual and therefore is influenced by the player's internal state.

A player's mood, capacity to process information, and environmental surroundings act as an invisible filter when judging games. We cannot label games as simply "good" or "bad" if our impression of it depends on external factors. Instead we must critique games with the context of our headspace in mind, recognising when sometimes games are not given a fair shot by the player due to the situation they played it in. Respecting this "headspace" isn't just crucial for how we critique games - it is a fundamental element of the player experience that game designers must respect.

Why Mood Impacts Review And Reception

In the modern gaming landscape, we rarely start a game completely blind. With the massive explosion of social media and the large gaming community, we are very likely as players to have a general idea of what we are about to play and what other

people think of the game. Sometimes this phenomenon can lead to us forgetting what works for us and instead forcing games because we consider them masterpieces. Recently, I made this exact mistake with Clair Obscur Expedition 33. This turn based RPG won practically every award that's ever existed and took over the gaming community last year. As a massive fan of turn based RPGs I felt it would be silly not to try it. What I failed to recognise were the expectations I took into the game and how this impacted my experience. When you enter a personal experience such as gaming with a pre-determined opinion, forged by the opinions of others, you lose the ability to be able to experience a game truly for yourself. It is undeniable that Expedition 33 is loved by so many. However, I got 10 hours into it before abandoning it. That doesn't make it a bad game. In reality, I realised the game does not match my personal taste however I was so fearful of missing out on what the community was calling a "masterpiece", I attempted to force the game to fit my taste. Once the initial hype faded, I realised the game was far too bleak for me. I play video games to relax, build connections with characters, and feel positive emotions. When a game doesn't match our personal taste, we can often label it as "bad" when in reality it just isn't for us. This is why I believe it is so important we form our own opinions of games rather than following the opinions of the community, because you never know the context behind their review, maybe they played it in the wrong environment, maybe they were having a bad day. The player's mood at the time can very severely impact their review.

This raises a key question: How do we know when we are in the right headspace for a game? In reality it is very tricky to find in ourselves in the absolutely perfect situation to experience a game. Often we begin a game, decide we are not enjoying it and decide to stop playing it, abandoning it into the library of games we will never touch again. Sometimes an opportunity will never present itself and we will never experience that game but that's okay. That is not us as a player missing out on an experience, but instead is us refining our taste and understanding what's for us. Fairly often, we will encounter a situation where a natural intrigue for the game builds up and an opportunity does present itself for us to play it, resulting in us as a player not forcing a game, but the game presenting itself to us when the moment is right. I experienced this earlier this year with a fantastic game called Dave The Diver. When Dave The Diver came out, my social media feed was flooded with people playing it and I couldn't resist the temptation to get it myself. At first I enjoyed it but it was nothing groundbreaking, and eventually I stopped playing it for a reason I cannot even remember, it just sat there in my library gathering dust. Until one day, I went on holiday down to the beach and wanted a game to play while I was away. Looking for something relaxing to play on my Steam Deck while listening to the

waves crashing, Dave The Diver came across my screen and it felt like the perfect relaxing game for my environment so I decided to play it and got absolutely hooked, completing it on that holiday and thoroughly enjoying it. My environment transformed a forgettable game into one of my favourite experiences I've played. That is why the context behind our gaming is so impactful and important.

Safe Havens And Comfort Zones

Just as a player's external environment shapes how a game is received, the internal environment of the game itself dictates how much a player can emotionally endure. As I said earlier, a game designer must respect a player's headspace while developing a game. They must also respect the emotional endurance of the player while considering the pacing of the game. A player must have rest in between high-impact moments to stabilise and reset their mind. High-impact moments have no effect if there is no baseline to compare them to. A game that immediately stands out for me as doing this well is the beginning of Life Is Strange Remastered. We start with a stressful moment with the storm dream, setting an immediate high-impact tone. Following that we return to a slightly less stressful moment as we are transported into the photography class. There's definitely still some tension here but the pacing has changed to be slightly more calming. The atmosphere is still stressful for Max - she is in a classroom full of people after crying and dealing with the dream - however, for the player, the tone has shifted dramatically. We then step out the classroom and are immediately transported into a tranquil environment as Max puts her headphones on and Syd Matters begins to play. The game is inviting us to take as long as we need with this quiet moment, giving us an opportunity to explore, learn about the characters we pass in the hallway and decompress before heading into the bathroom. The bathroom is an incredibly important moment in the game with plenty of high-impact action and lots to interact with. If the player was directed straight to the bathroom after the intense storm dream, the bathroom moment would feel much less impactful for the player and they would have less capacity to experience the large amount of emotion packed into that bathroom. This is an incredible showcase of how pacing can make a moment so much more impactful.

Pacing is an important component of any game, but it is equally important to give the player their own space to be able to dictate the pacing themselves. Pacing can be a very personal element of gaming, some people like to take their time and others need to rush, a great way to appeal to a variety of players is through comfort zones. These refer to areas of the game where players can spend as long as they need, explore and interact with characters. Great examples include: Max's bedroom in Life

Is Strange, Cafe LeBlanc in Persona 5, the camps in Expedition 33. Giving the player the power to dictate the pace at which they take the game at is an effective strategy for accommodating as many people as possible and improving the player experience. Without a safe haven like this, players may feel exhausted by the constant action of the game and frustrated by the lack of a break. Other elements can increase the effectiveness of a safe haven, from warm lighting to calming music. A game's music gives it a strong identity, allowing players to listen to the music and connect the feelings of that game to other aspects of their life. By giving the player space to sit with calming music like Life Is Strange does in that hallway scene, you allow the player to develop a connection with that music and use it to ground themselves in other situations. That connection uniquely enhances the player experience like no other element in a video game.

Conclusion: Playing And Designing Around The Mindset

Ultimately, video games are not static products. They are dynamic, two-way conversations between the game designer's artistry and the constantly shifting headspace of the player. When we stop labelling games with objective numerical scores to compare with each other, and begin to appreciate them as contextual experiences to discover, our relationship with the hobby immensely deepens.

As a player, this means being self-aware. Understanding when our current mood or environment is not fit for the journey a game is taking us on, even if that game is a masterpiece. It is recognising that abandoning a game is not a failure - it is saving the adventure for another more suitable time. It means stepping away from the collective hype of the community in order to protect our own interests and claim the hobby as our own personal experience.

As a game designer, respecting the player's mental state ensures the player doesn't just enjoy the experience but will never forget it. By carefully managing pacing, implementing comfort zones, and using atmosphere and music to give players room to breathe, developers can create spaces where players can process heavy emotions at their own pace without the emotions feeling like a heavy burden on their already busy lives. Respecting the player is what takes a game from a good experience to one that the player can pick up whenever they want and enjoy. That is how a deep connection between a game and a player can be made.

The next time we sit down, boot up a game, and feel that sudden urge to turn it off, perhaps we shouldn't ask what is wrong with the game or what is wrong with us. Instead, we should take a moment to analyse the world around us, check in on our own headspace, and realise that right now may not be the time. Sometimes, we just need to wait for the right moment to come. Because when the player's internal state, environment, and the game's design finally align, that is when deep everlasting connections between players and video games form, and that is the magic of video games.